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1924, *Matwala*

Hope exists that Bhagat Singh may yet assume centre stage in the annals of mainstream political history. This is because some of the most spirited claims on the legacy of Bhagat Singh already come from thoughtful Pakistani writers, even whilst recognizing the constraints to which they are subject. According to Ammara Ahmad, while Bhagat Singh ‘is a much loved and adored figure in Pakistan’, the problem is that ‘this doesn’t translate into public acceptance or acknowledgement of his efforts, cause or sacrifice’. As a result, ‘[h]is absence from the public discourse, memory and history books is as ubiquitous as that of Gandhi’s or Pakistani politician Sikandar Hyat Khan’s’. This is because although, ‘Singh was young, spirited and passionate enough to carry out what he believed in and then die for it’, the fact was that ‘he was also an atheist’. That being so, ‘he is naturally immune to being Islamised’ and that can be a problem for many Pakistanis conscious of the basis upon which their state was avowedly founded. For them, ‘[a]ccepting Singh as a national hero will also mean accepting the idea that one can be great without being a Muslim’ but that if this could be done, then it would indeed be possible for everyone to ‘realise that the Pakistan Movement was just one segment of the larger freedom struggle in India’. In this way, ‘Singh can indeed exemplify defiance against authority and illustrate why the British were the colonial enemies’. There are two arguments for suggesting that this should be done.

First, it is important today that we ‘understand that freedom in 1947 wasn’t just a “Muslim effort” but a combined effort of all religious communities’. It is remarkable how, with the passage of time, this singularly vital dimension of the Freedom Movement has all but been